Alveoli

Alveoli are tiny air sacs in the lungs that are located at the end of bronchial tubes, which is microscopic in nature. It is meant for the exchange of oxygen and carbon dioxide.

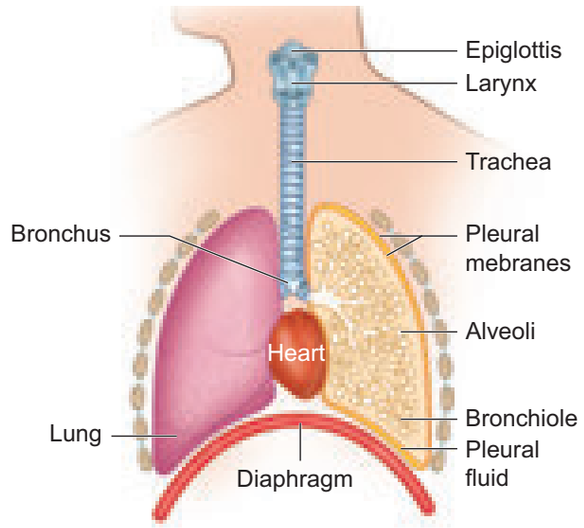


Figure 18.7 Human respiratory system

18.5.2 Mechanism of Breathing

Inspiration (Inhalation)

The process of taking air into the lungs is called **inspiration** or inhalation. During inspiration, the sternum is pushed up and outward and the diaphragm is pulled down. This increases the volume of the thoracic cavity and thus the pressure decreases. The air outside the body flows into the lungs. Here exchange of gases takes place between the air and the blood.

Expiration (Exhalation)

The process of expelling air from the lungs is called **expiration or exhalation.** Upon exhalation, the lungs recoil to force the air out of the lungs. The inter costal muscles relax, returning the chest wall to its original position. During exhalation, the diaphragm also relaxes, moving higher into the thoracic cavity. This increases the pressure within the thoracic cavity relative to the environment. Air rushes out of the lungs due to the pressure gradient. This movement of air out of the lungs is a passive event.

Exchange of gases in the Alveoli

The content of oxygen in the inhaled air in alveoli is more than the blood flowing through the capillaries. So, the oxygen moves into the blood by simple **diffusion**. **Haemoglobin** in the blood combines with **oxygen** to form **oxyhaemoglobin**. The blood carrying oxygen reaches the heart through blood vessels. The heart pumps it to all the tissues in the body. The tissues release carbon dioxide which is carried back to alveoli by the blood. Carbon dioxide diffuses from the blood to the air in the alveoli and is sent out of the body when the air is exhaled.

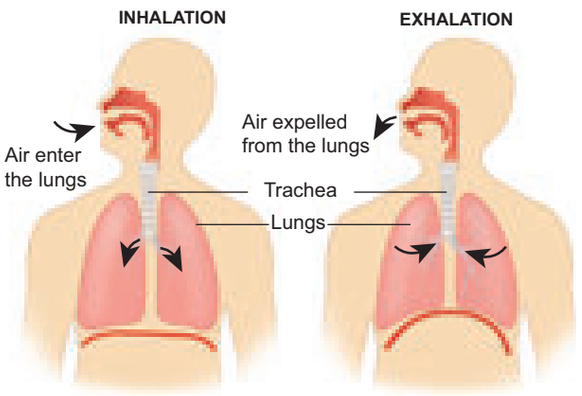


Figure 18.8 Inhalation and Exhalation

Table 18.1 Difference between inhalation and exhalation

Inhalation	Exhalation
The muscles of the diaphragm contract.	The muscles of the diaphragm relax.
The diaphragm goes downward.	The diaphragm goes upward.
The ribs move upwards and outwards.	The ribs move downwards.
The volume of thoracic (chest) cavity increases.	The volume of thoracic (chest) cavity decreases.
Air enters the lungs through the nose.	Air goes out of the lungs through the nose.

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